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Enhancing Female Entrepreneurship and Employment

MSME Sector in Chhattisgarh



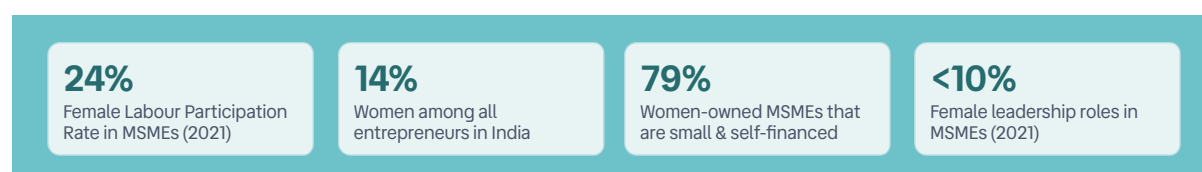


Enhancing Female Entrepreneurship and Employment in the MSME Sector in Chhattisgarh

Introduction

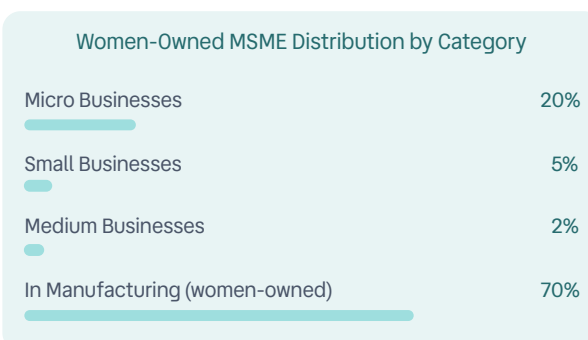
India has 63 million micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs). MSMEs already contribute around 30% to India's GDP and close to 50% of exports.¹ They account for almost 40% of India's manufacturing output and create around 11.10 crore jobs.² MSMEs have the capacity to generate employment, nurture entrepreneurship and bring in significant gains by plugging themselves into global value chains. The MSME sector in India has shown remarkable resilience even under the current trying domestic and global economic circumstances.

Another, often-overlooked contribution of the MSME sector is its potential to accelerate the economic inclusion of typically underrepresented groups, such as women. Indeed, MSMEs record a relatively higher female labour participation rate (24% in 2021) than other industries.³ However, this figure is still dismally low in absolute terms, and has stagnated over time. When it came to leadership roles in MSMEs, female participation was no more than 10% in 2021.⁴ Only 14% of all entrepreneurs are women, of which around 79% are small and self-financed.⁵



Women-Owned MSMEs- Scale & Distribution

Compared to their male-owned counterparts, female-owned MSMEs are fewer in number, smaller in scale and concentrated in different industries. Around 19.7 million MSMEs are involved in manufacturing, 23 million in trade, and 20.6 million in other services. Of these, only 15 million MSMEs are women-owned and 70% of them are involved in manufacturing, particularly in textiles, apparel, handicraft, and



1. Contribution of MSMEs to GDP", Ministry of Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises, Press Information Bureau, Government of India, 9th August 2021. Release ID: 1744032. <https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=1744032>
2. 2.2.4 Employment", Annual Report 2021-22, Ministry of Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises, Government of India: . 28.
3. Employment Trends in MSME Sector", Ciel HR Services, 2021.
4. Ciel HR Services, 2021.
5. Global Entrepreneurship Monitor India National Report 2020-21: . 10.
6. Opportunities and constraints of women-owned very small enterprises in India", International Finance Corporation, 2022: . 4-5. <https://www.ifc.org/wps/wcm/connect/2da6ccb4-5f11-4c25-8937-5a78ed26e9ce/Opportunities-and-Constraints-of-WVSEs-in-India.pdf?MOD=AJPERES&CVID=nZG2110>
7. 2.2.1 Estimated number of MSMEs in country", Annual Report 2021-22, Ministry of Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises, Government of India: . 26.
8. MSME Annual Report 2020-21.

food and beverages.⁶ Over 99% of MSMEs come under the 'Micro' category, with only 0.52% (or 331,000) enterprises coming under the 'Small' category, and 0.01% (or 5,000) enterprises coming under the 'Medium' category.⁷ Within these categories, no more than 20% of micro businesses, 5% of small businesses and 2% of medium-sized businesses are owned by women.⁸

"In this context, we propose a roundtable focused on women in the MSME sector and the policy issues they face. The roundtable aims to provide a closed-door platform to discuss the opportunities and challenges associated with female entrepreneurship and workforce participation at the ground level, to collate policy recommendations towards improving the ecosystem for women in the MSME sector."

Challenges Faced by Women Entrepreneurs:

Seminar Focus Areas⁹

Financial Inclusion

Many women entrepreneurs tend to resort to self-financing or informal sources of finance (often with higher interest rates), due to the lack of technical know-how or insufficient credit history. A vast majority of women do not have assets in their name to leverage as collateral. High documentation requirements present a further obstacle to obtaining credit. However, the gender gap in financing is not merely due to the lack of collateral: Credit received by women is only 27 % of the deposits they contribute, compared to 52 % for men.

Skill Development

Most women entrepreneurs participate in sectors requiring low technical education and skills, such as traditional goods or services (backyard poultry, tamarind collection, cashew cultivation, etc.). Women have low representation in sectors like metallurgy, electronics, minerals, pharmaceuticals, aeronautics, etc., which require a higher level of skills, education, technological sophistication and present significant barriers to entry. Women must be continually educated, skilled and qualified in all practical fields of business administration and STEM to gain technical expertise, other required skills and experience.

Market Connect

Women entrepreneurs have limited access to industry contacts, professional networks, mechanisms and know-how that are necessary for running and growing a business. Women participating in MSME activities may be more active in production rather than business management and product marketing. Market linkages are poor as MSMEs are located far from consumer markets and interactions with buyers are infrequent. Women are further hindered by low geographical mobility. As a result, female-owned MSMEs are unable to scale up and are largely micro-enterprises.

Regulatory Aid

Registration is a cumbersome process: Registering a business requires compliance with various norms like GST, labour regulations, electricity load, etc., which fall under the ambit of multiple regulators. This presents a challenge not only for MSMEs as a whole, but women in particular. While there are many state and central schemes, subsidies, incentives, tax/duty exemptions, training opportunities, etc. in place to support entrepreneurs, there is a need to improve awareness and take-up to translate them into better outcomes.

State Overview: Chhattisgarh

Geographic & Demographic Profile

Chhattisgarh is a landlocked state in central India, sharing borders with seven states: Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Jharkhand, Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana. The state has 33 districts, 122 revenue subdivisions, and 250 tehsils, spanning across 1,37,898 square kilometres. Its population stands at approximately 30 million, with around 60% falling within the working age group of 15–59 years.¹⁰

33

Districts across the state

122

Revenue Sub-divisions

250

Tehsils in the state

~30M

Population (60% aged 15–59)



Map of Chhattisgarh

Economic & Industrial Profile

The GDP of the state is estimated at USD 55.34 billion in 2022-23 and has increased at a CAGR of 10.64% between 2015-16 and 2022-23.¹¹ The state's robust growth can be attributed to its strong industrial sector.

Between 2011-12 and 2022-23, industry accounted for about 34.4% of the GVA by total economic activities in the state.¹² A small but modern industrial sector coexists with a large, low-productivity subsistence

9. The following papers informed our selection of focus areas: Opportunities and Challenges faced by Women Entrepreneurs in India. Gupta and Aggarwal (2015) Women's Access to Banking in India: Policy Context, Trends and Predictions. Chavan (2020) Women Entrepreneurship in Odisha: Current Status, Challenges and Future Prospects. Swagatika Nanda (2017)

10. <https://www.hindustantimes.com/cities/others/rajya-sabha-passes-bill-to-include-tribal-communities-in-scheduled-tribe-list-in-chhattisgarh-bjp-aims-to-woo-voters-101690360167678.html>

11. <https://www.ibef.org/states/chhattisgarh-presentation>

12. <https://theprint.in/economy/tale-of-2-poll-bound-states-why-chhattisgarh-is-doing-better-despite-parent-state-mps-faster-growth/1835706/>

agricultural sector. Nearly 80% of the state's population lives in rural areas and 70% of its population relies on agriculture, with 76% of 37.46 lakh farmer households falling under the small and marginal category.¹³

Key Economic Facts

- Industry accounted for about 34.4% of the GVA by total economic activities (2011-22)¹²
- ~80% of the state's population lives in rural areas
- 70% of its population relies on agriculture
- 76 of 37.46 lakh farmer households are small & marginal¹³

government undertakings like the Bhilai Steel Plant, National Mineral Development Corporation, South-Eastern Coal Field Limited, and NTPC are present in the state.¹⁵ Chhattisgarh also lays claim to the third largest forest cover in India, with over 40% of its territory under forest canopy.

Chhattisgarh possesses strong industrial facilities, with several upcoming infrastructural projects. Currently, the state has 19 industrial parks and is planning to set up to 300 industrial parks in rural areas.¹⁶ Major industrial areas include Dagori (Bilaspur), Tilda (Raipur), Lara (Raigarh) and

Known for its abundant resources, Chhattisgarh boasts the third largest coal reserves in the country, supplying electricity and coal nationwide. It has been declared a power surplus state.¹⁴ Chhattisgarh's rich

mineral deposits attract entrepreneurs, with about 27% of the state's revenue derived from mineral exploitation. Production of aluminium, iron and steel, tin, coal, dolomite, diamond, cement, and limestone are core sectors. Chhattisgarh is the only state that produces tin in India and accounts for approximately 30% of aluminium and steel produced in the country. The state leads the nation in freight loading, contributing one-sixth of Indian Railways' revenue. Several

Aluminium & Steel production share (national)	30%
Revenue from mineral exploitation	27%
Territory under forest canopy	40%+
National Railways freight (1/6th share)	~17%

Silphari (Bilaspur).¹⁷ Given Chhattisgarh's strategic and natural advantages, thrust areas for development identified by the government include agro-based and forest-based industries, mineral-based industries, handloom and handicrafts, IT, biotechnology, and infrastructure provisioning.¹⁸

13. https://finance.cg.gov.in/state_finance_commission/FSFC/Urban%20Local%20Bodies%20Report/English/Chap-9.pdf

14. <https://cgclimatechange.com/energy/#:~:text=Chhattisgarh%20has%20excellent%20power%20infrastructure,the%20power%20hub%20of%20India.>

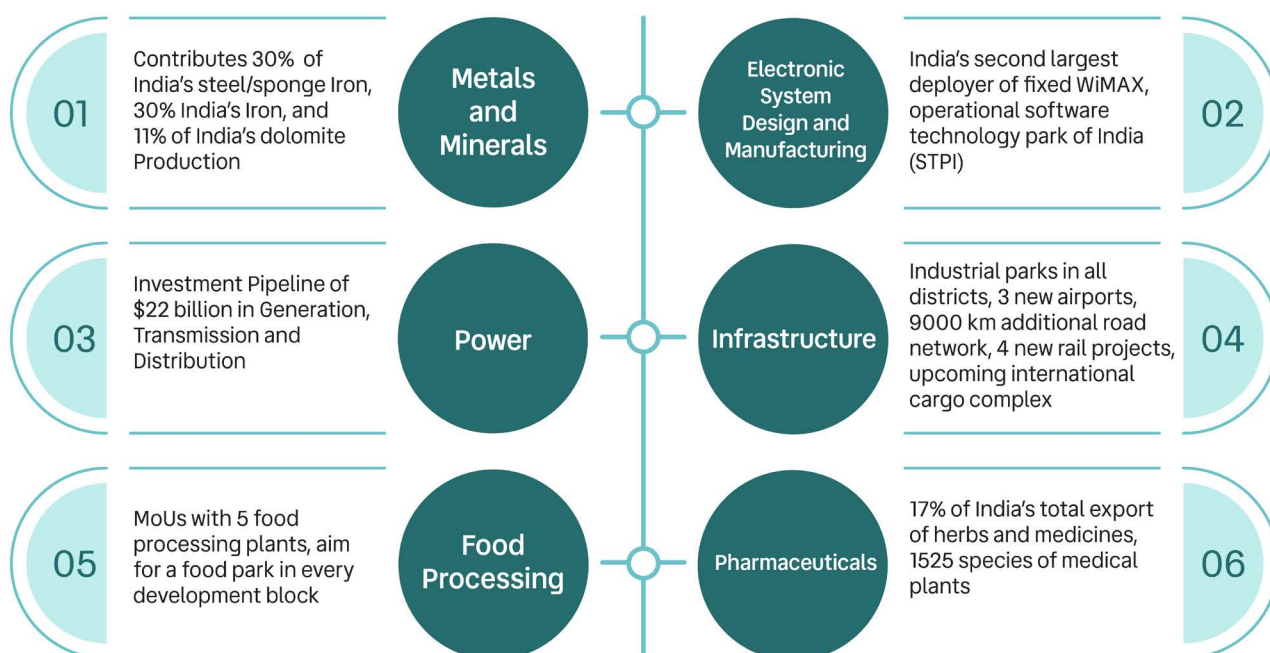
15. https://dcmsme.gov.in/old/dips/state_wise_dips/chhattisgarh.pdf

16. <https://www.investindia.gov.in/state/chhattisgarh>

17. https://industries.cg.gov.in/Industrial_Infrastructure.aspx

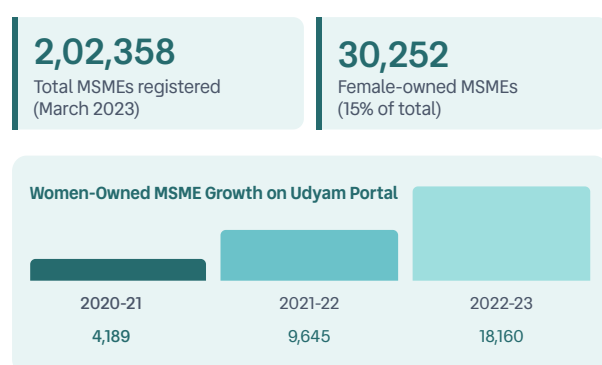
18. <https://msmediraipur.gov.in/chhattisgarh.htm>

Key Sectors and Highlights



MSME Sector in Chhattisgarh

The MSME sector occupies an important position in Chhattisgarh's industrial economy, contributing immensely to industrial production, export, employment, etc. As of March 2023, there are 2,02,358 MSMEs registered in the state, of which 30,252 (15%) are female-owned.¹⁹ Chhattisgarh has seen tremendous growth in the number of women-owned MSMEs registered on the Udyam Portal, up from 4,189 in 2020-21, to 9,645 in 2021-22, to 18,160 in 2022-23.²⁰



The strong presence of industrial hubs in Chhattisgarh offers many opportunities for downstream and ancillary MSMEs. For example, the Bhilai steel plant is associated with 175 ancillaries and 972 MSMEs supplying parts and components.²¹ By-products of such plants can be developed in the MSME sector, such as fly ash bricks and chemical products like phenyl and

19. <https://pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=1907502>

20. <https://pib.gov.in/PressReleaseDetail.aspx?PRID=1947401>

21. <https://msmediraipur.gov.in/chhattisgarh.htm>

22. https://www.nabard.org/auth/writereaddata/careernotices/0901210413Credit%20Potential%20for%20MSME%20in%20Chhattisgarh%20-%20Final_Sundari%20mam.pdf

23. https://dcmsme.gov.in/old/dips/state_wise_profile_16-17/STATE%20INDUSTRIAL%20PROFILE%20OF%20CHHATTISGARH-2016-17.pdf

naphthalene. Additionally, ancillaries and vendors have come up to address the service and maintenance needs of these large-scale manufacturing units.

The MSME sector in the state houses many steel re-rolling mills, mini steel plants, ferro alloy units, steel and cast-iron casting units,

engineering and fabrication units, as well as a large number of agro-based and food processing, chemical, plastic, construction material, and forest produce-based units.²²

The Ministry of MSME, Government of India, has recognised the following list of potential industries for prospective entrepreneurs in Chhattisgarh: ²³

Potential Industries for Prospective Entrepreneurs

- Mineral-Based Industries
- Agro-Based And Allied Food Enterprises
- Food Processing Industries
- Textile Products Including Hosiery
- Wooden Products
- Paper Products
- Leather And Rexene Products
- Plastic Products
- Chemical Products
- Ceramic Products
- Mechanical Products
- Electrical Products
- Farm Products
- Herbal and Ayurvedic Products
- Miscellaneous Products
- Service Enterprises

🕒 Traditional Handicraft Industry

Another important component of Chhattisgarh's MSME sector is the traditional handicraft industry, anchored to the state's cultural heritage. As per the Scheme of Fund for Regeneration of Traditional Industries, MSME clusters in handicrafts (including bamboo and dry flowers) have been identified in Bilaspur, Korba, Raipur, and Bastar. Chhattisgarh is celebrated for its bell metal, wrought iron crafts, bamboo work, wood carvings, tribal jewellery, and terracotta figurines.²⁵

NABARD identifies the following challenges in the MSME sector of Chhattisgarh:

Uneven spread of skilling institutions (particularly absent in the Bastar division and northern hills region), low intake capacity of skill training institutions, limited placement opportunities, poor supply of credit (as none of the public sector banks have specialised MSME bank branches in each district), low literacy rates, limited awareness of schemes, and low enrolment under vocational courses.²⁶

24. https://sfurti.msme.gov.in/SFURTI/Reports/DPR_Functional_Upto.aspx

25. <https://shoponline.cottageemporium.in/chhattisgarh-gi#:~:text=Astonishing%20bamboo%20work%2C%20wood%20carvings,the%20culture%2C%20are%20truly%20convincing.>

26. https://www.nabard.org/auth/writereaddata/careernotices/0901210413Credit%20Potential%20for%20MSME%20in%20Chhattisgarh%20-%20Final_Sundari%20mam.pdf

Tribal Women in the MSME Sector, Chhattisgarh

Tribal groups comprise 30% of Chhattisgarh's total population, with 42 reported tribal communities in the state.²⁷ Indigenous communities have traditionally maintained a distinct bond with the environment, adhering to a sustainable lifestyle. Tribal customs often involve reverence for nature, and the legal system grants tribes communal rights over land. Nevertheless, inadequate access to resources and developmental opportunities, coupled with prolonged neglect, have resulted in impoverished living conditions for many tribal groups. Challenges such as limited educational opportunities, high rates of school dropouts, malnutrition, and widespread poverty persist among India's tribal population.²⁸

Entrepreneurship allows tribal women to turn challenges into opportunities, overcome poor economic conditions, and better integrate themselves with the mainstream. Indeed, tribals have the highest percentage of women-owned enterprises across different social groups in Chhattisgarh at 4.41% (with SC women at 0.58% and OBC women at 0.71%).²⁹ Livelihood in the tribal community is typically not driven by market forces; rather, they pursue economic activities to fulfil their basic necessities without aiming for wealth accumulation.³⁰ This tendency may stem from a culture of contentment, where meaningful engagement takes precedence

over economic advancement. Moreover, tribal women possess indigenous knowledge and skills for collecting and processing natural resources like forest products in the most sustainable manner. Thus, the engagement of tribal women in the workforce is beneficial not only for them, but the MSME sector and society as a whole.

The highest proportion of the tribal population of the state resides in the Bastar and Surguja districts. In particular, the Bastar district is home to about 27% of Chhattisgarh's total tribal population and tribal groups make up 70% of Bastar's population.³¹ Bastar is divided into seven blocks/tehsils, namely Jagdalpur, Bastar, Bakavand, Lohandiguda, Tokakal, and Darbha, with Jagdalpur as its district headquarter. The tribal communities of Bastar are mainly the Gond, Maria, Muria, Bhadra, Halba, Dhurua communities, most of whom still reside in dense forests and are well-known for their culture, art, festivals, and natural lifestyles.

The total population of women in the district is an estimated 4.21 lakhs. The Bastar district has a high sex ratio with 1024 females for every 1000 males. About 71.5 thousand i.e. 17% of the women are engaged in agriculture, allied activities and cottage industries. About 90% women in the district are employed in the primary sector.³²

27. https://www.nabard.org/auth/writereaddata/tender/2009160534Livelihood_mapping_in_Bastar_Chhattisgarh.pdf

28. <https://bastar.gov.in/en/about-district/#:~:text=There%20are%2070%20percent%20tribal,Bhatra%2C%20Halba%2C%20Dhruva%20community>

29. https://www.nabard.org/auth/writereaddata/tender/2009160534Livelihood_mapping_in_Bastar_Chhattisgarh.pdf

30. Acharya, G. K., Shrey R., Pandey A., Pandey M. & Dwivedi R. (2017). Entrepreneurship development of tribal women in Bastar district of Chhattisgarh. Agric. Update, 12 (TECHSEAR-7): 1923-1926 http://researchjournal.co.in/upload/assignments/12_1923-1926.pdf

31. Chaturvedani, A. K., Lal, N., Khalid, Khyalia, N. K., and Pratap, J. (2015). Empowering Tribal Women Through Backyard Poultry in Bastar District of Chhattisgarh. J Krishi Vigyan. Vol. 3- Special Issue.

32. <https://www.indianjournals.com/ijor.aspx?target=ijor:jkv&volume=3&issue=2s&article=005&type=pdf>

Livelihood Opportunities for Tribal Women Entrepreneurs in Bastar, Chhattisgarh

Tribal communities in Bastar typically engage in agriculture and allied activities (horticulture, forestry, poultry, piggery), non-timber forest products (NTFPs), handicraft, construction services, etc. In tribal communities, women serve as the primary earners, taking on various responsibilities such as caring for the family and children, engaging in labour work, gathering forest produce, and crafting drinks like Mahuwa, Landa, and Salfi from local resources to sell in nearby markets. Every

week, local markets known as shandies/haat/bazaars are organized in nearby areas. In many parts of the district, women trek long distances of 15-20 km to attend these markets, where they sell forest products and poultry.

"Entrepreneurship allows tribal women to turn challenges into opportunities, overcome poor economic conditions, and better integrate themselves with the mainstream."



Key Tribal Livelihood Activities

Non-Timber Forest Products (NTFPs)

Acharya (et al, 2017)³³ highlight how the collection, processing and selling of non-timber forest products (NTFPs) constitute the major economic activities of the tribal population. NTFPs include Mahua, Tamarind, Tendu Leaves, Mushrooms, Harra, Baheda, Chironjee, Aonla, Honey, Mahul Leaves, Lac, Gums, Resins, Tikhur, Cashew-nut etc. In India, Chhattisgarh is abundantly rich in NTFPs owing to the large and dense forest cover, with the Bastar district contributing up to 40% of the country's NTFP production. Tribal women were the highest contributors in terms of average number of hours and days

spent collecting NTFPs (about 6 hours and 86.3 days respectively), quantity collected per person per day (57%) and quantity processed per person per day (80.85%). Women were also the highest earners per day per person for NTFP-related activities, constituting 65.62% of the total collectors. However, women lagged men in marketing NTFPs by almost 45%. The article suggests that tribal women should be supported in their activities and more mechanisms must be facilitated to increase their income through NTFPs.

Backyard poultry

Chaturvedani (et al, 2015)³⁴ show that backyard poultry is an important livelihood option among the rural tribal residents in Bastar. It helps them out of poverty and deprivation, with great levels of female participation in various allied activities. Backyard poultry is helping increase the household income, nutrition levels and gender parity in tribal households. Women contribute immensely in production, management and marketing activities. Backyard poultry, this study concludes,

improves tribal livelihood, and contributes toward women empowerment. Backyard poultry activity is traditional livelihood among the tribal and non-tribal communities and especially actively managed by the women. It is a subsidiary activity for a large tribal population and primary source for families engaged with chicken meat trade. More than 95% of the tribal families, especially the women, either individually, in SHGs, or under contractors collect or sell tamarind through organised and unorganised channels.

Handicrafts

The tribes of Bastar were amongst the earliest to work with metal and have expertise in making beautiful figurines of tribal gods, votive animals, oil lamps, and more. Tribal handicrafts of Bastar are increasingly winning market attention at the national and

international levels. However, volume and consistent quality in production are seen as barriers to growth.³⁵

Jain and Chandravanshi (2022)³⁶ conducts a SWOT analysis to understand the economy

of Bastar and the current and potential contribution of handicraft towards improving the standards of living and livelihood for its people. Even though the industry is highly unorganised and low-paying, the Chhattisgarh handicraft development board registers a total of 1,563 craft-wise handicraft artisans. The study concludes that

promoting tribal handicraft is the best way to boost Bastar's economy and gives pragmatic suggestions like developing a systematic market for Bastar's handicraft products both domestically and internationally, while helping the artisans with financial help and fixed wage rates.

Agricultural products and agro-processing

Rathour (et al, 2022)³⁷ reveals that tribal women entrepreneurs were mostly associated with farmer producer organisations (FPOs) for minor millet production & marketing activity (82.05%). Other FPO activities include Amchoor Processing & Marketing, Tamarind Collection & Marketing, Vegetable Production & Marketing, Turmeric Production

& Marketing, Non-FPO activities (Wages). The study also shows that membership of FPOs helps in increasing the income of tribal women entrepreneurs, with up to a 493.70% increase in turmeric production & marketing. It also highlights how longer memberships have consistently increased the income of tribal women shareholders in FPOs.

Construction services

Providing construction services also constitutes a significant aspect of tribal livelihoods. This is evident from the substantial number of tribal families residing

in various parts of the district who migrate to Jagadalpur within a radius of 5-35 kilometres to offer their labour, particularly in masonry work.



33. Acharya, G. K., Shrey R., Pandey A., Pandey M. & Dwivedi R. (2017). Entrepreneurship development of tribal women in Bastar district of Chhattisgarh. Agric. Update, 12 (TECHSEAR-7): 1923-1926 http://researchjournal.co.in/upload/assignments/12_1923-1926.pdf

34. Chaturvedani, A. K., Lal, N., Khalid, Khyalia, N. K., and Pratap, J. (2015). Empowering Tribal Women Through Backyard Poultry in Bastar District of Chhattisgarh. J Krishi Vigyan. Vol. 3- Special Issue. <https://www.indianjournals.com/ijor.aspx?target=ijor:jkv&volume=3&issue=2&article=005&type=pdf>

35. https://www.nabard.org/auth/writereaddata/tender/2009160534Livelihood_mapping_in_Bastar_Chhattisgarh.pdf

Schemes for Women and Tribal Entrepreneurs in Chhattisgarh

The government has acknowledged that for economic and social upliftment of the MSME sector, it is necessary to provide additional benefits to some groups, including women entrepreneurs and tribal entrepreneurs.

Towards uplifting the MSME sector as a whole, the Chhattisgarh state government's policies have emphasised ease of doing

business, industrial infrastructure, a cluster development approach, marketing assistance through the E-marketing Network of Chhattisgarh platform (E-MANEC), entrepreneurship and skill development, export promotion, and financial incentives through subsidies and exemptions to eligible industries.³⁸

Central-level schemes

Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana (PMMY)^{39,40}: Under this scheme, non-corporate and non-farming small and micro entrepreneurs can avail loans up to 10 lakh rupees. Loans under the scheme are provided through regional rural banks, commercial banks, non-banking financial corporations, small finance banks, etc., with the provision of applying for it directly on the Udyamimitra portal. In the financial year 2023-24, 6,48,56,820 loans were sanctioned, amounting to 5,21,603.96 crores. As of November 2023, 69% of the loans sanctioned were to women entrepreneurs. In the year 2022-23- women held more than 71% of the loan accounts

Integrated Tribal Development Program^{41,42}: This scheme is funded by Tribal Development Fund (TDF) by NABARD, and aims for sustainable development of tribal families. Some of the benefits of the scheme include long-term income generating activities undertaken by tribals, improved quality of life for the beneficiary families, building institutions and self-help groups, etc. In the year 2022-23, the sanctioned amount from TDF was 5.56 crores for the state of Chhattisgarh. TDF also provides training on processing and marketing, community building, and women empowerment. 57,163 families have benefitted from the tribal development program in Chhattisgarh alone.

Micro and Small Enterprises Cluster Development Programme (MSE-CDP)⁴³: The schemes of Cluster Development and Integrated Infrastructural Development (IID) culminate together in the MSE-CDP scheme. This is a national scheme; state governments must send proposals for establishing CFCs and IIDs as per cluster requirements in their respective states. Chhattisgarh has 11 approved IID centres of which 7 are completed. Women can benefit from several Government of India grants under this scheme, which are higher than other non-recognised categories.

36. Jain, N., and Chandravanshi, J. (2022). Role of Tribal Handicraft in the Development of the Rural Economy of Bastar, Chhattisgarh. *Arthavati : An International Journal*. Vol. 9 Issue-1&2 <https://arthavati.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/03/Arthavati-Journal-Vol-9.pdf#page=95>

37. Rathour V, Tiwari P. K., Pandey P. K., Singh K. P., Singh D. P. (2022). Socio-Economic Upliftment of Tribal Women through FPO in Bastar District of Chhattisgarh. Vol. 58, No. 4 (October–December).

Stand Up India Scheme⁴⁴: This scheme is funded by Tribal Development Fund (TDF) by NABARD, and aims for sustainable development of tribal families. Some of the benefits of the scheme include long-term income generating activities undertaken by tribals, improved quality of life for the beneficiary families, building institutions and self-help groups, etc. In the year 2022-23, the sanctioned amount from TDF was 5.56 crores for the state of Chhattisgarh. TDF also provides training on processing and marketing, community building, and women empowerment. 57,163 families have benefitted from the tribal development program in Chhattisgarh alone.

Adivasi Mahila Sashaktikaran Yojana (AMSY): This scheme is funded by Tribal Development Fund (TDF) by NABARD, and aims for sustainable development of tribal families. Some of the benefits of the scheme include long-term income generating activities undertaken by tribals, improved quality of life for the beneficiary families, building institutions and self-help groups, etc. In the year 2022-23, the sanctioned amount from TDF was 5.56 crores for the state of Chhattisgarh. TDF also provides training on processing and marketing, community building, and women empowerment. 57,163 families have benefitted from the tribal development program in Chhattisgarh alone.

Pradhan Mantri Jan Jaatiya Vikas Mission⁴⁵: The scheme is rolled out by the central government and aims to further the entrepreneurship opportunities and skills of tribal groups in India. It puts into place a stable mechanism for procurement, processing, production, and marketing of tribal produce. 100% grant-in-aid is promised by the Government of India (GoI) to the Tribal Cooperative Marketing Development Federation of India (TRIFED). The scheme promotes tribal development through enhancing year-long income generating activities, market links and institutional support.

Other schemes by National Scheduled Tribes Finance and Development Corporation (NSTFDC)⁴⁶: National Scheduled Tribes Finance and Development Corporation (NSTFDC) provide more schemes for tribal economic development. These include Term Loan Scheme, Micro Credit Scheme for Self Help Groups (MCF), Skill & Entrepreneurship Development and Marketing Support Assistance through State Channelizing Agencies (SCAs).

38. https://www.nabard.org/auth/writereaddata/careernotices/0901210413Credit%20Potential%20for%20MSME%20in%20Chhattisgarh%20-%20Final_Sundari%20mam.pdf

39. <https://www.mudra.org.in/>, <https://www.livemint.com/economy/women-major-beneficiaries-of-mudra-and-stand-up-india-schemes-11702904294123.html>

40. <https://www.mudra.org.in/>

41. https://ced.gujarat.gov.in/assets/downloads/new_guidelines_cluster.pdf

42. <https://pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=1982305>

43. <https://sansad.in/getFile/loksabhaquestions/annex/1712/AU637.pdf?source=pqals>, https://www.nabard.org/demo/auth/writereaddata/File/TDF_Projects_Status_as_on_Sept_2015.pdf, https://www.nabard.org/auth/writereaddata/tender/pub_300623094538471.pdf

44. <https://www.livemint.com/economy/women-major-beneficiaries-of-mudra-and-stand-up-india-schemes-11702904294123.html>, <https://www.standupmitra.in/Home/SUISchemes>, <https://vikaspedia.in/social-welfare/scheduled-caste-welfare-1/best-practices-in-implementation-of-stand-upindia>

45. https://loksabhadocs.nic.in/Refinput/New_Reference_Notes/English/17072023_171620_102120526.pdf

46. <https://sansad.in/getFile/loksabhaquestions/annex/1714/AS218.pdf?source=pqals#:~:text=Ministry%20is%20implementing%20the%20scheme,more%20efficient%2C%20equitable%2C%20self%2D>, [https://nstfdc.tribal.gov.in/\(S\(tqadnihqmylggd4vverjvxxk\)\)/frm_sed.aspx](https://nstfdc.tribal.gov.in/(S(tqadnihqmylggd4vverjvxxk))/frm_sed.aspx)

State-level schemes

Chhattisgarh Industrial Policy 2019-2024⁴⁷

The policy defines women entrepreneurs as “domicile women of the State who has proposed to establish/ has established industry, in case of partnership firm, minimum 51% partnership; in case of company incorporated under Indian Companies Act, minimum 51% shareholding; in case of co-operative society minimum 51% member and in case of society formed under Society Act, minimum 51% members should be women from the State of Chhattisgarh and minimum 50% of total employment in

industry should be women in managerial, skilled and unskilled categories.”

In addition to the incentives enumerated for MSMEs, industries set up by women entrepreneurs and SC/ST categories receive 10% additional incentives, a 10% higher ceiling of incentives, and an extended time limit of one additional year.

Women can also avail a 25% Margin Money Subsidy on a capital investment of Rs. 5 crores for the establishment of new industries, the maximum limit on which will be Rs. 50 lakhs.

Women Entrepreneur Definition — Requirements:

- Partnership firm: minimum 51% partnership
- Company (Companies Act): minimum 51% shareholding
- Co-operative society: minimum 51% membership
- Society (Society Act): minimum 51% women members
- Minimum 50% total employment in managerial, skilled & unskilled categories

Start-up Chhattisgarh Scheme 2024^{48,49,50}

‘Promotion of Women Entrepreneurs’ is one of the broad pillars of Chhattisgarh’s Start-up Policy, with tailored incentives and schemes for women-led start-ups. Tribals and women are promised an additional 10% grant and discount, and an additional year for availing these benefits. The state offers a separate corpus out of the Innovation Fund, Leap of

Faith Revolving Fund and Venture capital Fund of more than Rs. 100 crores will be earmarked for women innovators to motivate and empower women entrepreneurs in the state. The incentive proposal includes a monthly sustenance allowance and state specific quota for women-led start-ups for funding grants and incubation support.

47. <https://industries.cg.gov.in/startupcg/pdf/policy2019-24/Industrial%20Policy%202019-24%20English%2019-05-2020.pdf>

48. <https://industries.cg.gov.in/startupcg/pdf/startup%20package%202019-24.pdf>

49. https://www.startupindia.gov.in/srf-2022/reports/Chhattisgarh_State_Report_09-06-2022.pdf

50. https://www.startupindia.gov.in/content/sih/en/women_entrepreneurs.html

State Women Entrepreneurship Policy, 2023-28^{51,52}

To support women entrepreneurs and increase their work efficiency, this policy aims to provide women with financial support in many ways. Under this policy, provisions have been made for loans up to Rs 50 lakhs for manufacturing enterprise projects for women entrepreneurs, up to Rs 25 lakhs for service enterprise projects, and up to Rs 10 lakhs for business enterprise projects. Economic investment incentives will be provided to the new, expansion, micro, small and medium manufacturing, and service enterprises established by women entrepreneurs in the state. Fixed capital investment grants of up to 30-55% of the fixed capital investment

made in the enterprise, term loans received for enterprises and interest subsidy of 45 to 70% on working capital (equivalent to a maximum of three months requirement) provided in the project report and a maximum amount of Rs 15 to 60 lakh will be given. Margin money grants up to 50% for setting up of new enterprises, up to a maximum of Rs 75 lakh, net state goods and services tax (net SGST) reimbursement for 6 to 16 years from the date of commencement of commercial production, electricity duty, stamp duty, transport grant, mandi fee will be exempted. Provisions have also been made for women self-help groups (SHGs).

Chhattisgarh MSME Policy⁵³

This policy was created to fill in the gaps created by the new industrial policy to bring in more investments in Chhattisgarh. One of the clear objectives of this policy is to help the economic development of women by giving additional incentives to women entrepreneurs in the state.

Financial Support Structure — Key Provisions

Manufacturing enterprise loans	Up to ₹50L
Service enterprise loans	Up to ₹25L
Business enterprise loans	Up to ₹10L
Fixed capital investment grant	30–55%
Working capital interest subsidy	45–70%
Margin money grant (new enterprises)	Up to 50%

Tech for Tribals⁵⁴

This program is an initiative of TRIFED (Tribal Co-operative Marketing Development Federation of India) with Chhattisgarh MFP (Minor Forest Produce) Federation and IIT Kanpur to provide holistic development to tribals. It tries to bridge the gap between tribal entrepreneurs and urban markets.

Soft Skill Development

Provides training of several kinds including soft skill development, IT, business and entrepreneurship development to Vandhan tribal beneficiaries.

Bridging Market Gap

Connects tribal entrepreneurs with urban markets by building digital and business management skills.

There is a need to evaluate the on-ground success of the various schemes in effect, and identify what further regulatory aid is required.

51. <https://www.drishtiias.com/statepcs/08-06-2023/chhattisgarh/print#:~:text=Under%20the%20State%20Women%20Entrepreneurship,lakh%20for%20business%20enterprise%20projects.>

52. <https://acrobat.adobe.com/id/urn:aaid:sc:VA6C2:8d6cc33c-627c-4680-94fd-ae6e537db6aa?viewer%21megaVerb=group-discover>

53. <https://msme.icaai.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/06/MSME-POLICY-IN-CG.pdf>

54. <https://pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=1663702>

The Bastar Roundtable

Pahle India Foundation, with support from the Bastar Samajik Jan Vikas Samiti, organised a seminar at Jagdalpur, Bastar. A total of 30 tribal women entrepreneurs from the Bastar district of Chhattisgarh participated in the roundtable. Participants came from different blocks of Bastar, including Bakawand, Darbha, Jagdalpur, and Tokapal.

They primarily belonged to the age group of 20-40 years, with two attendees aged under 20 and two above 40 years of age. The majority of the women entrepreneurs were involved in tailoring and sewing. They shared the following insights into the day-to-day challenges they face in their profession.



Challenges identified at the roundtable

Access to Finance

- All the participants had bank accounts and most of them kept earnings in their account. However, a few stored money at home despite having an account.
- Despite increased access to borrowings through bank accounts, a majority did not avail loans from the bank. Among the reasons cited were high interest rates, discouragement from the bank, and the bank locations being distant from their place of residence.
- Tribal women receive meagre incomes from the sewing-tailoring business, exacerbated by intense local competition.
- There was a lack of awareness about loans, schemes, and interest rates under the Udyam registration process.
- Personalised assistance from NGOs and civil society organisations is highly necessary to guide tribal women towards available benefits.

Market Connect

- Women were unable to access markets, as markets were located far away from their tribal dwellings. This presented a major constraint, forcing women to sell their produce locally.
- Participants believed that accessing markets in city and urban centres would help them realise a better price for their products.
- The enterprises had limited online presence, with participants relying heavily on local referrals for business.
- E-commerce integration would help participants expand market reach and reduce dependence on local networks.
- Female entrepreneurs need to develop independent networking skills and establish direct connections with relevant agencies.

Skill Development

- Women are faced with the lack of direction after completing training programs, particularly in terms of putting learnings into action.
- Less than half of the participants had not attended any form of training.
- Training related to marketing, business expansion, financial literacy, technology utilisation, and trade are the most needed by women entrepreneurs, based on their responses.



Information Dissemination

- The Panchayat remains the primary source of information, but efforts are underway to improve communication through initiatives like I-cards and E-Shram cards.
- There are challenges in reaching women entrepreneurs through Aanganwadi schemes and ensuring comprehensive dissemination of beneficial schemes. While the provisions for Aanganwadis were available, they were significantly understaffed.
- Master trainers and NGOs play a critical role in door-to-door communication for spreading awareness, particularly improving communication of benefits available to tribal women entrepreneurs.

Family Support

- Women entrepreneurs cited inadequate family support as a significant hurdle, facing the dual responsibilities of professional work and household duties.
- Instances where husbands provided little to no support made it challenging for women to balance their personal and professional life.

Lack of Awareness Around Government Schemes

- There was limited awareness around government schemes, attributed to the lack of communication channels and technological inaccessibility



Tribal women entrepreneurs at the Bastar roundtable



The Raipur Roundtable

A roundtable was held in Raipur on 10th April 2024, inviting MSME stakeholders such as government dignitaries, banking officials, NGO heads, and tribal entrepreneurs to discuss the challenges and opportunities faced by tribal women entrepreneurs in the state. An audience of 20+ people from various sectors was present. Participants shared the following insights at the roundtable.

Cultural Sensitivity towards Tribal Values: Connection to Land and Culture of Contentment

- For tribal communities, their connection to their land is sacred. They are comfortable within their own traditions, vicinity and community, and are often unwilling to travel across borders or cultural boundaries.
 - The seasonal nature of agriculture and low agricultural productivity forces tribal individuals to maintain diverse occupations. Many migrate to work as contractors in industries such as construction and mining, but this is an undesirable last resort for them.
 - Money does not drive tribal society. Instead, it is viewed as a means to achieve satisfaction. It is essential to define 'development' in their own terms, wherein livelihood is closely tied to respect, dignity, and the quality of life.
 - Participants recounted stories of tribal workers turning down placements, promotions, and pay raises due to long working hours or travel requirements. Government offices in areas like Bacheli are reportedly unable to meet their obligations to recruit apprentices and face a high rate of attrition due to the lack of tribal interest. In the healthcare domain, tribal women are unwilling to be admitted to hospitals overnight, and prefer same-day walk-ins.
 - Any mode of intervention in the tribal community should study tribal life patterns closely and take their values for granted, rather than impose subjective views of good and bad.
- We should reject the perception that tribal culture is backward. Many aspects of tribal life can be seen as more progressive than urban lifestyles, e.g. their proximity to nature and respect for personal choice in the ghottul system of courtship.

Designing Culturally-Compatible Occupational Training

- Occupational training offered in tribal areas must integrate indigenous and culturally compatible practices into the workstream, so that women can engage in activities applicable to their milieu. The same standardised training cannot be offered in urban and tribal settings. Some participants expressed doubts that the courses commonly offered to women, e.g. beauty training, fit within the tribal context. Upskilling in activities they are already familiar with, e.g. livelihoods linked to the forest, is ideal.
- Trainers should be selected from a pool of local community leaders, so that they can become cultural role models to emulate.
- Training must be made accessible for tribals with low levels of literacy.
- Techniques like participatory rural appraisal (PRA) should be used to incorporate indigenous knowledge into the planning and management of schemes.
- An example of an intervention that meets the needs of tribal women effectively is the Intel Udyogini School of Entrepreneurship (funded by Intel and executed by NGO Udyogini). The organisation tailors a basic three-month enterprise development course towards less literate and rural populations through interactive methods (e.g. skits and roleplay) and a mobile school, which maintains the link to the locality and ensures accessibility.

Economic Opportunities for Female Tribal Entrepreneurs

- An example of a venture that successfully connects indigenous culture with market value is Bastar se Bazar Tak, a forest-to-fork business founded by Mr. Satendrasingh Lilhare. Headquartered in Chhattisgarh, the for-profit social enterprise conducts post-harvest management of non-timber forest produce (fruits and nuts, vegetables, fish, medicinal plants, resins, fragrances, fibers, etc.) and sells directly to the market, eliminating intermediaries. The company employs 1500 tribal women farmers in three verticals and has gained 60 institutional buyers over time under the 'Forest Naturals' label. It aims to grow into a social unicorn.
- Roadside dhabas and eateries see high participation from tribal women, and are a viable option for their livelihood. The SHG-run Sakhi Cafe in Kashmir is a successful model.
- Cultivation of lac (natural resin secreted from lac insects) can be done simultaneously with agriculture, and has many uses in paint, jewellery, pharmaceutical coating, food, and the electric industry.
- Rising demand for millets like kodo, kutki, and ragi should be tapped by the tribal community.
- The carbohydrate-rich Mahua fruit holds cultural importance and economic significance in Adivasi culture, and can be developed into various fermented and non-fermented food products, including liquor, biscuits, laddoo, tea, etc. Bastar mahua liquor can be developed into a heritage brand and marketed widely, akin to Goa's feni and Kerala's toddy.

- o The legal framework needs to evolve to accommodate and catalyse the Mahua opportunity. ST households have clearance to store only up to 5 litres of mahua liquor. To develop this industry, it would be beneficial to designate it as a heritage liquor (as Madhya Pradesh has done), grant GI status, enable NABL and FSSAI certification, designate SHGs of ST women to package and sell the product, etc. A door-to-door collection system (as for milk, directly from producers) could be set up.
- Most trade of non-timber forest products (NTFPs) takes place in the black market. The supply chain must be integrated to remove middlemen and encourage trade transparency, measurement, and accounting. Entrepreneurs should take advantage of government financial assistance to set up cold storages.

Popularity of Tailoring Courses Among Women: A Strong Preference for Flexibility

- At the Bastar roundtable, issues of intense local competition and low earnings in the sewing-tailoring field came up, as the tribal women attendees had all trained in the same course. At the Raipur roundtable, government officials provided insights into how these training courses are selected and designed.
- There are 13 Jan Shikshan Sansthan in Chhattisgarh, including in tribal-dominated areas like Bastar, Bijapur, Surguja, etc. The scheme, which was previously under the Ministry of Education, has been transferred to the Ministry of Skill Development. It is up to the local JSS to survey the area to evaluate the scope for training and identify skills that have a market in the region.
- The aim of the JSS scheme is to improve the occupational skills and technical knowledge of non-literates, neo-literates, and school drop-outs to enhance their livelihood opportunities. Priority is given to women, SC/STs, OBCs, and minority groups.
- Given this background, the apparel course emerges as a popular option, as it is accessible across all education levels. Tailoring is a highly desirable course among ST women, because it is secure and does not require them to travel, being flexible in terms of geography and working hours.
- Tribal women are extremely hardworking, facing the dual burden of household duties and agricultural work. As their leisure hours are limited, they need work that can be done at any time of the day to accommodate their busy schedule.
- Even under the Vishwakarma scheme, the vast majority of beneficiaries (especially women) register for the tailoring (darzi) course.

Intel Udyogini School of Entrepreneurship: An example of an intervention that meets the needs of tribal women effectively. Funded by Intel and executed by NGO Udyogini, the organisation tailors a basic three-month enterprise development course towards less literate and rural populations through interactive methods (e.g. skits and roleplay) and a mobile school, which maintains the link to the locality and ensures accessibility.

Need for Post-training Feedback Mechanisms and Follow-up Agencies

- Interventions need to be objective-driven. A supply-driven, project-driven, or fund-based approach will not be effective.
- A woman will only take forward the learnings from a course if she is interested; many take up beautician courses and either drop them in the middle, or do not end up opening a beauty parlour. They must feel an internal drive to work and generate income for themselves and their family.
- Under all schemes of the Government of India, there should be a provision for post-training handholding support, activity-tracking, and focused follow-up interventions. These tasks can be assigned to a separate implementing agency, with field staff to conduct routine visits. The implementing agency can also aid the loan recovery process, providing an end-to-end solution to minimising NPAs rather than abandoning beneficiaries of loans in the middle.
- There should be a feedback mechanism to track each individual enrolled and trained in schemes to ascertain whether they are implementing the skills in practice, whether they have moved into entrepreneurship, whether the scheme allowed them to generate more economic returns than before, whether their business performance or development condition has improved, whether they have availed loans, what they have spent the loan on, etc.
- Schemes should learn from the success of the Swachh Bharat Mission, which was aggressively marketed, had a strong support structure (with the door-to-door collection of buckets), awareness-building across all verticals of waste (e.g. of geela and sukha kachra), partnership with SHGs, practice of feedback collection, etc. Mindsets change and impact becomes visible when the right support infrastructure is created.



The PIF team with tribal women entrepreneurs in Bastar

Rising Momentum for the PM Vishwakarma Yojana

- Government officials expressed hope and rising momentum around the PM Vishwakarma Yojana, a central sector scheme launched in September 2023 to support traditional artisans and craftsmen. The scheme offers training in 23 trades, 4-5 of which are related to traditional tribal livelihoods. Approximately 9000 have been trained in Chhattisgarh as of May 2024.
- The scheme involves basic training of 5-7 days and advanced training of 15 days or more, with a stipend for wage loss compensation of Rs. 500 per day and a toolkit grant of INR 15,000 in e-vouchers. It also offers recognition through an ID card and certificate.
- Courses not only enhance skills, but promote scheme awareness and offer marketing training. For a total course duration of 40 hours, the skilling portion is limited to 18 hours, while 22 hours are spent on business process training, customer care, how to use the Bhim UPI system, briefing about the banking system from bank officials, etc.
- Participants become eligible for collateral-free enterprise development loans at a concessional exchange rate of 5% in two tranches as they complete trainings. After undergoing basic training, a first tranche of INR 1 lakh can be availed, for repayment in 18 months. A condition set is that the beneficiary must not have received a loan previously, which makes many tribal individuals eligible. After undergoing advanced training (or maintaining a standard loan account and adopting digital transactions), beneficiaries can avail a second tranche of INR 2 lakhs, for repayment in 30 months.
- The loans are catered through MSME branches of banks, of which there are many in the industrial state of Chhattisgarh. However, officials indicate that due to risk aversion in the tribal community, loan take-up remains low, particularly for larger sums.
- The scheme is jointly implemented by 3 ministries: The Ministry of Micro, Small & Medium Enterprises, the Department of Financial Services, and the Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship.
- Strong MIS infrastructure is in place to track implementation: Data about all trainings given is housed on this NSDC portal. An incentive of INR 1 per digital transaction is credited to the beneficiary's account (up to 100 transactions each month); this serves as an in-built indicator of how many people are using the facility.
- The scheme is still nascent, with the second phase of advanced training yet to be implemented. At this stage, information dissemination is the main challenge.

Responding to Prevailing Demand for Skills: Content Creation and Tourism

- We need to move beyond preconceived stereotypes limiting women entrepreneurs to producing achaar, papad, and chutney. We should think outside the box. Training should enable women to harness their interests and entrepreneurial opportunities as they arise. Institutions aiming to offer skill development training should be open and flexible in responding to demand at the ground level for skill-sets.
- Many youths in remote areas use mobile phones and create social media content, despite poor network access. The government has recognised that the digital creator economy is growing fast, even in rural areas. Youngsters can be empowered to leverage their own interests to pursue new-age entrepreneurial careers like travel vlogging and food vlogging through training in content monetisation, digital marketing, etc.
- Many non-tribal groups are cashing in on Bastar's rise as a tourist hub through experiential living, homestays, etc. Adivasis should be able to benefit from the rise of the tourism industry in their communities. For example, the local women who know the area best can be engaged as tour guides.

Challenges to Marketing Tribal Products

- Due to low technical know-how of smartphones and poor network connectivity in remote tribal areas, digital marketing and e-commerce are not accessible to tribal groups.
- Many do not see the need for packaging, branding, and marketing, preferring to rely on their local geographical monopoly for sales.
- To remove middlemen and ensure the right remuneration for their products, producers must learn to see themselves as entrepreneurs and not merely artisans.
- Tribal livelihood can be enhanced through efforts to redesign existing products.

Need for Equal Rights to Land and Inheritance

- ST women are excluded from the Hindu Succession Act, 1956 and Indian Succession Act, 1925, largely to preserve tribal customary laws governing ancestral property. A majority of tribal societies in the country are patriarchal in nature, where inheritance rights devolve only in the male lineage and tribal women do not enjoy equal entitlement rights as their male counterparts. Even in culturally matrilineal societies, the land deed is ultimately often registered in a man's name.
- Ownership over land or assets will enable women to access credit through collateral and encourage them to take the lead more often.

Tribal Capital and Financing

- The tribal understanding of capital is different; while the urban populace is happy to entrust their earnings in formal financial instruments like Fixed Deposits, tribal individuals tend to have more faith in tangible assets like land and livestock.
- With bank branches and ATMs located far from rural tribal dwellings, access to formal finance is limited.
- Moreover, tribes have yet to develop trust in the formal financial system. Factors behind this may include low exposure, lack of respect received during bank visits, fear of bank fraud, etc. Whenever required, many prefer to obtain loans from relatives or informal brokers.
- Legalising tribal land sales to non-tribals is under discussion in many states. In times of financial crisis, Adivasis should not be forced to sever their sacred link to their land. Schemes should offer them financial support in times of need, rather than leave them to their own devices.

Empowering Tribal Women and Reinstating Pride

- In Chhattisgarh, pride in tribal culture and self-reliant attitudes are eroding, given their history of suffering and deprivation. There is a need to reverse this trend.
- Tribal livelihood, in the most part, is dependent on laborious subsistence agriculture. Women perform most agricultural activities, but it is men who are called farmers. Women must be assigned credit for the work they are already doing.
- Not all women are interested in entrepreneurship, and may still prefer the stability of wage employment in manufacturing, services, trade, etc. Schemes for employment generation like MNREGA are highly necessary.
- Basic indicators of welfare still have a long way to go in tribal areas, from schooling to nutrition. Tribals must be sensitised to reallocate their expenditure basket towards health and education, as they tend to spend more on family functions and cultural activities.



The Raipur roundtable

Policy Recommendations

Offering occupational training that links indigenous and culturally compatible practices to market value, with a focus on livelihoods that preserve the tribal connection to land and the forest. Work for tribal women must also allow for much-needed flexibility.

Training programmes can be prepared keeping in mind the available geographical resources and traditional activities adopted by the respective tribes. The promotion of mahua products (liquor, biscuits, tea, etc.), millets, lac cultivation, eateries, cold storage infrastructure, and tourism hold significant economic potential in the tribal belt of Chhattisgarh.

Ensuring training is accessible in rural areas and tailored to those with low literacy levels through mobile schools and interactive methods.

Under each government scheme, implementing post-training handholding support and follow-up interventions. Establishing a feedback mechanism to track the impact of training schemes on individual beneficiaries. Successful models like the Swachh Bharat Mission, emphasising strong support infrastructure and continuous feedback, can be emulated.

Providing diverse training in skills that have a market in the region, taking into account local competition and earning potential. These may be previously untapped and unexpected opportunities, moving beyond stereotypes that limit women entrepreneurship to achar, papad, and chutney. Empowering youth to leverage their interests in new-age entrepreneurial careers, like content creation.

Enhancing marketing strategies for tribal products through better packaging, branding, and market integration. Encouraging producers to see themselves as entrepreneurs and providing training in value addition and marketing.

Supporting wage employment opportunities alongside entrepreneurship, ensuring stability and security for those who prefer it.

Building tribal trust in the formal financial system by increasing access to banks and ATMs in remote areas and establishing lines of communication.

Offering financial support to Adivasis during times of financial need to prevent them from having to resort to selling their sacred land.

Advocating for equal land and inheritance rights for ST women to enable access to credit and encourage leadership.

Avoiding external definitions of development; instead, aligning initiatives with the community's own terms of respect, dignity, and quality of life.



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